RAMBAM'S INTRODUCTION TO HELEK: OLAM HABA & THE 13 PRINCIPLES

No Body, No Form: The Third Principle

Rambam's Introduction to Helek, Part 10

Source: The Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek: Principle 3, *Shelilat HaGashmiyut*

Shiur: Part 10 of the series on the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 9 December 2025 (the week before Chanukah)

These notes are based on the transcript of the recording.

The Text

היסוד השלישי: שלילת הגשמות ממנו. וזה, שנאמין כי האחד הזה שזכרנו אינו גוף ולא כח בגוף, ולא ישיגוהו מאורעות הגופים, כמו התנועה והמנוחה והמשכן, לא מצד עצמותו ולא במקרה. ולכן שללו ממנו חכמים זכרונם לברכה החבור והפירוד, ואמרו: אין למעלה לא ישיבה ולא עמידה, לא עורף ולא עיפוי, כלומר לא פירוד ולא חבור... ואמר הנביא: ואל מי תדמיוני ואשוה, יאמר קדוש. ואילו היה גוף, היה דומה לגופים. וכל מה שבא בכתבי הקודש מתארים אותו בתארי הגופות, כמו הליכה ועמידה וישיבה ודבור, הכל דרך השאלה. וכן אמרו: דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם. וכבר דברו חכמים בזה הענין הרבה. והיסוד השלישי הזה מורה עליו מה שנאמר: כי לא ראיתם כל תמונה.

Phrase	Meaning
אינו גוף ולא כח בגוף	**No body, and no bodily force**
מאורעות הגופים	**Movement, rest, dwelling**: not inherently, not incidentally
אין למעלה לא ישיבה ולא עמידה, לא עורף ולא עיפוי	No sitting or standing, **no division (*oref) and no joining (ipui)*.** Ipui***, from*** ***ועפו בכתף פלשתים** (Yeshayahu 11:14), **joined shoulder to shoulder**
ואל מי תדמיוני ואשוה	**If He had a body, He'd resemble bodies**
הכל דרך השאלה; דברה תורה כלשון בני אדם	**Every bodily description is borrowed language**
כי לא ראיתם כל (Va'etchanan) **תמונה**	**At Sinai you saw no image**, because there **is** none

"The Sages spoke about this a lot"? "**Nowhere in the Talmud** does it say this. **He must mean *philosophers*.**"

Ani Ma'amin captures it exactly: **שהבורא... אינו גוף, ולא ישיגוהו משיגי הגוף, ואין לו שום דמיון כלל.**
Yigdal: אין לו דמות הגוף ואינו גוף, לא נערוך אליו קדושתו.

Part 1: It Follows From Principles 1 and 2

Perfection means **no limitation**; **unity** means **no limitation**. Anything physical **has a measure**.

"However big you imagine God, **a huge throne in the sky, a huge body and a long beard**, it still has **a measurement**."

Yesodei HaTorah 1: אילו היה היוצר גוף וגויה, היה לו קץ ותכלית, שאי אפשר להיות גוף שאין לו קץ, וכל שיש לגופו קץ ותכלית יש לכחו קץ וסוף. ואלהינו ברוך שמו, הואיל וכחו אין לו קץ ואינו פוסק... אין כחו כח הגוף. והואיל ואינו גוף, לא יארעו לו מאורעות הגופות.

Abarbanel asks: so why list it **separately**? "**The simple answer: because so many people believed God has some form.** Logically it follows; **he felt it had to be said explicitly.**"

Part 2: Why It Matters, and How to Live With Imagery

Rabbi Sacks, *zichrono livrachah*, asked by an atheist ***why did God create atheists?***, answered: ***to keep us in check.*** "**When faith is challenged, we're forced to define it**, and to make it **more intellectual and rational**." This principle forces **a mature understanding**: "**we should be proud to say we don't believe in a God on a throne in the sky with a beard, waving a wand.**"

"We think in images"

"**It's absolutely fine** to speak of God physically, **as long as we know it's a symbol, not a representation.** We're human; **we think in images.**"

Algebra. "Working out **wallpaper** for a house with the builder, you talk about **2x, 3z, 4y** as if they had their own identity. **Fine, as long as at some point you translate back into actual wallpaper.**" Even the most rational believer uses imagery.

Examples: Father, King; **וירד ה' לראות את העיר ואת המגדל**; **יושב בשמים ישחק** (Noach, a few weeks ago); **דע מה למעלה ממך** (Avot); **עמוד מכסא דין ושב בכסא רחמים**.

Why "in heaven"? "**Hashem is nowhere and everywhere.** In heaven *only*, He'd be enclosed: **limited**." **Rav Bloch (*Shiurei Da'at*): psychologically we venerate what's high.** So we lift our eyes in the Amidah, **אשא עיני אל ההרים**. "**All fine, all imagery.** Just know it's imagery."

"If I knew Him, I would be Him"

Rav Yosef Albo (*Ikkarim* 2:30): a sage was asked whether he knew God's essence: **אילו ידעתיו הייתיו**. **Only He grasps His essence.**

"**What** He is, we don't know. **That** He is, we do." We can speak of **how He acts** in the world, **not of what He is**.

Part 3: The Hardest Principle

"**The hardest principle to accept, in my opinion.** Not because I doubt it. **Of course I believe it**, and philosophically it makes complete sense. **The problem is calling its deniers heretics with no portion in Olam HaBa.**"

How severe the Rambam is

Hilchot Teshuvah 3: המינים ... ואלו שאין להם חלק לעולם הבא: one who denies God; one who believes in **two**; **והאומר שיש שם רבון אחד, אבל שהוא גוף ובעל תמונה**.

The Moreh (1:36) goes further:

One who believes God has a body **is without doubt worse than an idolater**; he **provokes and angers** God **far more**.

Defend him as simple, ignorant, raised that way? **The idolater too worshipped only from ignorance and upbringing**, yet we make no allowance for him.

The elephant (Moreh 1:60)

You've never seen or heard of an **elephant**. Someone you trust says one exists. Then he describes it: **one leg, three wings, lives in the sea, a transparent body, a human face, speaks like a man, sometimes flies, sometimes swims.**

Do you say *you believe in elephants, just refine your picture*? Or *you don't believe in elephants at all*? "**What he describes has nothing to do with elephants.**"

So too: one who believes in a God with form **doesn't believe in God.** "**Like praying to a ruler, or to a cupboard.** However much you pray, **that's not God.**"

Problem 1: the Torah reads as if God has a body

"**An unartificial reading of the entire Torah is a physical God.**"

- **נעשה אדם בצלמנו כדמותנו**
- **ויראו את אלהי ישראל, ותחת רגליו כמעשה לבנת הספיר** (Mishpatim)
- **וראית את אחרי ופני לא יראו**

And the Rambam's proof-verses can be answered: *you saw no image* may mean **He didn't reveal it**; *to whom will you compare Me* may mean **a form unlike any other**.

"**I'm 100% certain the Rambam is right** and these are metaphorical. **But why penalise the innocent believer?**"

Problem 2: no source in Chazal either

All twelve other principles have a source, in the Torah or at least the Talmud (Mashiach and resurrection in the **Mishnah**). **This one has none.** The Talmud even describes God bodily: **Rabbi Yishmael saw Hashem wearing tefillin** (Berachot).

- **The first to say it explicitly: Rav Saadia Gaon** (900s), in *Emunot veDeot*.
- **But Targum Onkelos** (the convert, ~200s CE) consistently **softens** every physical description: "**He clearly didn't believe in a physical God, 100%.**" He just didn't **say** it.

The answer for the innocent: the A-level student

"**I'm very sorry. You were taught wrong. But you don't believe in God.** For the Rambam, Olam HaBa **is** intellectual and moral perfection: **you can't enjoy an Olam HaBa you've completely misunderstood.**"

"**A student applies to study maths at university with no A-level.** He brings a doctor's note: **two years in bed with cancer**. They'll say: *we're so sorry, we wish we could help, but without A-level maths you don't have the concepts.***"

The Ra'avad: "greater and better than him"

למה קרא לזה מין? וכמה גדולים וטובים ממנו הלכו בזו המחשבה, לפי מה שראו במקראות.

Why call him a heretic? Many greater and better than he held this view, from what they saw in scripture. (He **agrees** God has no body.)

"Greater than *him*", the Rambam? "The *poskim* were **very troubled**."

- **The Kesef Mishneh** (the Beit Yosef): it **can't** have been said; **a different text**.

- **Rabbi Vidal of Tolosa** (Maggid Mishneh): **ממנו** = "**from among us**," not "than him."

The Radbaz: an **honest** mistake isn't heresy: **Hillel** (in the Talmud) held there'd be **no Mashiach**, yet isn't called a *kofer*. **שאין כפירתו... אלא מפני שחושב שמה שנראה בעיניו אמת, והוא אנוס ופטור.**

Rishonim who held God has form

Rabbi Moshe Taku (Tosafist, 13th century), "quite unconventional": the Torah is **literal**: Hashem has **a throne and sits on it**. *How can He know everything from one place?* **That's His greatness.**

- He also denied Hashem **fills all existence** ("**the song: *Hashem is here, Hashem is there, Hashem is truly everywhere***"): not in **impure** places. "An immature understanding," against **Rav Saadia's** mainstream view.

- **His proof (Sanhedrin 46b): twin brothers**, one a **king**, one a **robber**. The robber hanged looks like the king, so the hanged are buried the same day. **Man is in God's image, so God has a form.** "**Easily disprovable, completely wrong. But the simple reading is on his side.**"

Rashi? "Some academics argue **Rashi** believed in a physical God, e.g. **ממש את ידי** — *My literal hand*. See the **Maskil LeDavid**. **I don't know enough about it.**"

The Rambam knew: in the *Letter on Resurrection* he writes of **would-be sages, even sitting dayanim, who believe God is physical**. "**And he still calls them heretics.**"

Where to land?

The mainstream: the Rambam is right that God has no body, **but one who believes otherwise because of simple upbringing isn't punished**: **Sefer HaIkkarim**, **the Ra'avad**, **Rabbeinu Bachya**.

The challot in the ark. "In **Tzfat**, a simple man left **challot in the Aron Kodesh** each Friday, *a gift for Hashem*. Each Shabbat morning they were gone: *Baruch Hashem, He ate them!* (The **shamash** threw them out.) One Friday **the rabbi** caught him: *How foolish!* He stopped. **The Arizal** came to that rabbi: ***since the Temple was destroyed, Hashem's greatest pleasure was that man's challot.*** A classic hyperbolic Arizal story. **The point: simplicity isn't penalised.**"

"**I'm not sure which view to take.** Intellectually, I think the Rambam is right: **without that understanding you can't have Olam HaBa.** Emotionally, **it's very difficult**: people who served Hashem their whole lives, who brought *korbanot* thinking He eats them..."

Part 4: Two Final Points

Teaching children

Moreh 1:35: incorporeality **must be taught to everyone**, **children, women, the simplest**, just as we teach that Hashem is **one**. "We can tell kids *Hashem sits in heaven judging us* on Rosh Hashanah. **Every so often, remind them: we don't mean it literally.**"

- **Sefer Chassidim** (Rabbi Yehudah HaChassid, 12th century): teaching children that Hashem is in heaven, **point upwards**.
- **Berachot 48a: Abaye and Rava** as boys, asked by Rabbah *to Whom do we bless? where is He?*: **Rava pointed to the ceiling; Abaye went outside and pointed to the heavens.** *Both will become rabbis.*

Why would the Torah mislead?

Moreh 1:46 ("**quite shocking**"): the masses had to be brought to God **progressively**: first a **corporeal** God, **an improvement on many gods**; only later **incorporeality**. "**Essentially the Torah tells you something not true, to lead you to something more developed.** There are problems with that; look it up yourself."

Summary

1. **Principle 3:** Hashem has **no body, no bodily force**, none of a body's states; all bodily language is **borrowed**. **It follows from perfection and unity**, but was listed **because so many believed otherwise**.
2. **Imagery is fine as symbol** (algebra; "in heaven" because **we venerate height**), **translated back** now and then. **We know *that* He is, not *what*.**
3. **The hardest principle:** for the Rambam, a corporealist is **worse than an idolater**: **the elephant with one leg and three wings.**
4. **The problems:** the **Torah reads physically**, and **no source in Chazal** (only **Onkelos** implicitly, then **Rav Saadia** explicitly). Answers: *the student without A-levels*; but the **Ra'avad**, **Radbaz** and **Ikkarim** won't call the innocent heretics. **Rabbi Moshe Taku** held God has form; perhaps **Rashi**.
5. **The Tzfat challot**: simplicity not penalised. "**Intellectually the Rambam; emotionally, difficult.**"
6. **Teach children** God has no body (Abaye and Rava pointing up). **The Torah's anthropomorphism is a staged pedagogy** (Moreh 1:46).

Coming Up

Next Tuesday, the final shiur of the term (at 8, after candle-lighting; **no Monday or Thursday shiur for Chanukah**): **Principles 4 and 5**.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/A7OzALV7rtw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com